Collections Maintenance Procedures

The systematic evaluation, replacement and withdrawal of circulating materials is a crucial component of collection development and is as important to maintain relevant library collections as the influx of new materials. The reevaluation of all library materials in light of constantly expanding areas of knowledge, cultural shifts, technological advances, and changing community needs, requires a thoughtful, informed, and responsive approach.

The goal for each location is to serve the needs of its active users by maintaining a collection which is diverse, inclusive, current, relevant, and in good physical condition. s collection maintenance model gives each location flexibility and autonomy to ensure its collection is centered around its local neighborhood community, while acknowledging its place in the broader system as a resource for patrons across the borough.

Staff should use Collection Management Policy as a crucial tool when evaluating materials currently in the collection. Although it is the goal for a branch collection to contain materials of the highest interest and use to local patrons, it is of the utmost importance that collection remain as diverse and inclusive as possible, so that patrons may see a range of people and cultures represented on the shelves, and not the opinions and values of staff or a segment of patrons. In many cases, this will mean retaining items that may not be as popular with branch patrons, but which contain content that is current and relevant for a wider variety of communities.

collections within the BPL organization may adhere to their own collections maintenance procedures. Withdrawal procedures listed generally apply only to the library's physical circulating collection.

Staff Role in Collection Maintenance

It is the responsibility of librarians to participate actively and consistently in the ongoing maintenance of their branch materials collection. Training of librarians in collection maintenance procedures should be given a high priority.

- Branch Managers are responsible for training Assistant Branch Managers in collection maintenance, with the support of the Customer Experience Department.
- Assistant Branch Managers are responsible for training, assigning, and monitoring staff involvement in collection maintenance.
- Each librarian should maintain a current and relevant collection by weeding, using Replacement Ordering, Rebalancing, and placing requests for new titles with the BookOps Selection team.
- Although not required, branches might wish to designate certain items as "core" if they are foundational to the scope of the branch's collection and relevance to the community. Core items also ensure that a collection will be diverse, inclusive, and reflective of all in a community, regardless of usage and circulation statistics.

Selection Procedures

Selection

Materials are selected by a centralized team of professional librarians. They expertly choose print and digital works using the criteria outlined in the Materials Selection section of Collections Management Policy, and enhance these decisions using circulation data, community demographics, and input from staff and the public alike. The team's structure ensures a collection that is cost-efficient, consistent, diverse, inclusive, and meets the educational and recreational needs of the community.

More information about ordering timelines and workflows can be found on the Ordering page on the Staff Wiki.

Replacement Ordering

Replacement Ordering is a system for branches to request replacement or additional copies of titles already in the branch's collection, titles that other branches have, or even titles that were once purchased but no longer have copies in the system. It is an important part of maintaining healthy, community-centered collections. Reasons for ordering replacements include replacing grubby or damaged copies, ordering current titles on a popular topic for which you have outdated titles, obtaining titles frequently assigned to students by local schools, and more.

The Replacement Ordering procedure is documented on the Replacement Ordering Staff Wiki page.

New Title Requests

Requests for titles that are not currently and have never been in our collection can be made to the Selection team. New title requests may be warranted when a patron requests a book that staff agree might be a good addition to the collection rather than a candidate for Interlibrary Loan; when staff are planning a program (ex. an author talk) that relies on titles we do not currently own; staff independently encounter a title that they feel might be a good addition to the collection.

The BookOps Selection ticketing procedure is documented on the ServiceNow Staff Wiki page.

Request to Purchase

The Request to Purchase form is an avenue for the public to recommend new materials for the collection, to the Materials Selection team. This includes specific titles and authors, as well as general requests for subjects or topics. A request does not guarantee a purchase. The Materials Selection team reviews each request and evaluates it according to the criteria in the Materials Selection policy.

The Request to Purchase Form is available on More information can be found on the Request to Purchase page on the Staff wiki.

Author and Publisher Submissions

When an author or publisher would like to submit their own work for consideration for our Submission Guidelines for Authors and Publishers.

A submission does not guarantee a purchase. The Materials Selection team reviews each request and evaluates it according to the criteria in the Materials Selection policy.

The Submission Guidelines for Authors and Publishers can be found on BPL's website.

Interlibrary Loan

books that are not in our collection, from other U.S. libraries. Cardholders must place ILL requests in person at any branch. If a copy becomes available, the cardholder will be notified using their preferred method of communication.

The Interlibrary Loan procedures and a link to the patron request form can be found on the Interlibrary Loan Staff Wiki page.

Withdrawal Procedures

Weeding

Weeding is the process of regularly removing materials from a branch collection, based on specific criteria (weeding guidelines and criteria can be found below). Weeding is essential to make space on the shelves for new titles and enhance their appeal and discoverability. A crowded shelf can bury materials, whereas a curated shelf gives the items space and invites engagement from patrons.

Poor condition or outdated materials should be weeded and then discarded. Good condition, current materials that are weeded due to low usage or space concerns can be offered to other BPL locations and given a second chance to circulate (rebalancing). Weeding guidelines can be found on the Weeding Staff Wiki page.

Rebalancing

Rebalancing is the process of transferring materials owned from one branch collection to another. If an item is in good condition, current, and relevant, staff may choose to offer it up to be claimed by other locations for their collections. Rebalancing promotes collection sharing, extends the life of purchased items, and gives librarians an additional tool for collection curation. Rebalancing is an alternative to completely withdrawing an item from the library's collection; however, if a rebalanced item is not claimed, the owning location may then decide to withdraw it.

An item offered in rebalancing for at least one month without being claimed can be withdrawn from the collection.

The Rebalancing procedure can be found on the Rebalancing Staff Wiki page.

Discarding Materials

Library materials are purchased with public funds and staff must adhere to the library's discard procedures. Library materials are resold to an approved library vendor (e.g. Thrift Books) and this money is distributed back to BPL. Staff are not permitted to take, resell, or donate weeded items.

Community members interested in repurchasing or donating weeded library materials to other orgs should check out withdrawn library items for resale on ThriftBooks.

Staff should follow regular discard procedures outlined on the Weeding Staff Wiki page when withdrawing materials.

BPL has several approved procedures to recirculate weeded collections for community need.

> Community Collection
> Staff may elect to place a collection of items with a local community organization, checked out to a Community Card, for the benefit of community members who cannot visit BPL in person. The Community Collections procedure can be found on the Community Collection Staff Wiki page.
>
> Jail & Prison Services Collection
> Outreach Services' Justice Initiatives team will accept certain items discarded from the collection to be used in their jail library collection. Please read their Jail & Prison Services Book Donation Guidelines on the B-Line before sending any materials.

Weeding Guidelines

The following are effective criteria for evaluating items:

Condition
Materials should be withdrawn if they are no longer usable or physically unappealing. Items in the following conditions should be withdrawn:

- Grubby items: items that are worn or shabby (ex. deteriorating, yellowing, cracking, or flaking paper, disintegrating binding, loose or unattached pages)
- Damaged items (including water damage, bug infestation, pen/ink marks)
- Soiled or stained items
- DVD sets with missing discs
- Read-along books with broken components

Currency
Older materials with outdated content should be withdrawn. If an edition of a title is superseded by a newer edition, the older edition may be withdrawn. When evaluating, keep in mind that there should be a representative sample of a topic in a particular

section, especially in non-fiction. Ensure you have considered a plan for a replacement, if needed, when an item is withdrawn. Replacement Ordering is a good tool for keeping a range of information on a topic.

Here are guidelines on how frequently to evaluate items for weeding by section. These are just guidelines and not every title is going to fall within them (some might pass their prime earlier or later). Superseded editions should be withdrawn, regardless of how recently they were published.

- Fiction – 4 years
- Nonfiction
    - 000 Computer Science, Information & General Works – 3 years
    - 100 Philosophy & Psychology – 4 years
    - 200 Religion – 5 years
    - 300 Social Sciences – 3 years
    - 400 Language – 5 years
    - 500 Science – 2 years
    - 600 Technology – 2 years
    - 700 Arts & Recreation – 3 years
    - 800 Literature – 5 years
    - 900 History & Geography – 4 years
    - Biography – 2 years
    - Reference – 2 years (exempting a dictionary or thesaurus)

Relevance

The relevance of materials can be determined by assessing community interest, and usage.

Interest - Staff can determine public interest in portions of the collection by using a variety of methods including:

- Referencing circulation data captured by the Integrated Library System (ILS), BklynSTAT, and collectionHQ.
- Using anecdotal evidence and experiences with patrons, including reference questions, readers advisory, and community outreach.
- If a book has not been checked out in one year and it has no significance to the community (ex. local history) and is not part of the branch's core collection, consider it for rebalancing (if it meets the criteria for condition, currency, and relevance) or withdrawal.

- NOTE: Although a branch collection should reflect local interests, it is of the utmost importance to maintain a diverse and inclusive collection. Any patron should be able to walk in and see themselves reflected on the shelves. Please review our Materials Selection Policy and use

Usage – Staff can learn a lot by observing how patrons use the collection.

- Consider language needs of the community, using the above tools.
- Consider usage patterns (ex. are patrons using materials in the branch but not checking them out?)
- Consider highly represented age groups and/or community-based needs such as schools and nursing homes.

Space

As a circulating public library, it is not our role to keep anything other than what is of current use and interest to our patrons. Here are some helpful ways of thinking about the space:

- Use of space and visual appeal of the collection is an important factor in circulation.
- Limit presence of duplicate copies on shelves
- Avoid overcrowding. A good target is for shelves to be about 75% full.
- For every item on the shelf that is no longer relevant or desired, there is a more suitable item that could be in its place.

Resources Referenced in this Document

Collections Management Policy
Community Collection
Interlibrary Loan
Ordering
Rebalancing
Replacement Ordering
Request to Purchase
ServiceNow
Submission Guidelines for Authors and Publishers
Weeding